4

The Countercultural Church

> I will put together my church, a church so expansive with energy that not even the gates of hell will be able to keep it out.
>
> Jesus (Matt. 16:18 Message)

In writing about the teaching of Jesus, John Stott noted that "if the church realistically accepted his standards and values . . . and lived by them, it would be the alternative society he always intended it to be, and would offer to the world an authentic Christian counter-culture."[1]

Those two ideas—church and counterculture—lie at the heart of reaching a post-Christian generation. The challenge is, first, to understand the ideas and, second, to engage them. Let's start with understanding, for if there is any doctrine that is ignored or grossly misunderstood by Christ followers—at least among evangelical Christians in the United States—it is the doctrine of the church.

I remember, when I was a seminary president, sitting in a boardroom with a prominent Christian business leader and trying to pitch a vision for him to contribute to theological education, specifically student scholarships.[2] Instead of listening to the opportunity or asking pertinent questions as to the value of such an investment, he was determined to boast of his company's identity as a Christian enterprise. He told of the mission trips he had taken with his employees, the investments his company had made in select boutique parachurch ventures, and the Bible study offered on campus for employees. Throughout his self-congratulatory spiel, he took more than his fair share of shots at local churches and pastors who were not as "alive" as he and members of his company were in their faith.

At the time, as a new seminary president facing an inherited budgetary shortfall of over one million dollars, I was willing to endure almost anything—or anyone—for aid. Then in the midst of one of his personal asides about the sorry state of the church, as compared to the pristine missional nature of his business, he maintained that it was for this reason that he wasn't involved in a local church. They were, he intimated, beneath his own theological vision. "And after all," he added, "we're the church too."

And then everything within me wanted to leap from my seat, shout, "Enough!," and say, "No, you are not!" As I wrote in *Christ Among the Dragons*:

> A company is *not* the body of Christ instituted as the hope of the world by Jesus Himself, chronicled breathtakingly by Luke through the book of Acts, and shaped in thinking and practice by the apostle Paul through letter after letter now captured in the New Testament. A marketplace venture which offers itself on the New York Stock Exchange is not the

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entity which is so expansive with energy that not even the gates of hell can withstand its onslaught. An assembly of employees in cubicles working for end-of-year stock options and bonuses is not the gathering of saints bristling with the power of spiritual gifts as they mobilize to provide justice for the oppressed, service to the widow and the orphan, and compassion for the poor.

I then added these words:

With jaw-dropping vigor, ignorance, and at times unblushing gall, increasing sectors of the evangelical world are abandoning two thousand years of ecclesiology as if the church was some malleable human construct that can be shaped, altered, redefined or even disposed of as desired. This, coupled with a radical revisionism in terms of biblical interpretation and ecclesial history that would seem more in line with *The Da Vinci Code* than Christian theology, the doctrine of the church is being reformulated apart from biblical moorings, or simply dismissed as if not a part of biblical orthodoxy at all.

I stand by those words.

The Idea of Church

The word *church*, from the Greek word *ecclesia*, literally means "the called-out ones."[3] It is a word that was used in Jesus's day for any group that was gathered together for a specific purpose or mission. Jesus seized the term to speak of a group with a *very* specific purpose or mission, setting it apart from every other group or mission. This is where *ecclesiology*, which is the theological term for the doctrine of the church, finds its origin. The church of Christ is anything but a man-made organization; it was founded and instituted by Jesus himself (Matt. 16:18).

In the Bible, there are three primary understandings of this church: the local church; the universal church as it exists around the world; and the church as it exists throughout time and history, incorporating all the saints who will one day be gathered together in heaven. Without question, the dominant biblical use is in reference to a local church, or collection of local churches, as a defined body of believers who are gathered with both intent and order. Think of how the letters of Paul were written: "to the church of God at Corinth," "to the churches in Galatia," "to the church of the Thessalonians." And John's Revelation begins, "To the seven churches in the province of Asia."

This church is to serve as the ongoing manifestation of Christ himself on earth, being called his body, an idea of profound significance throughout the New Testament. As the apostle Paul writes, "Just as each of us has one body with many members, and these members do not all have the same function, so in Christ we, though many, form one body, and each member belongs to all the others. We have different gifts, according to the grace given to each of us" (Rom. 12:4–6). Later in the New Testament, Paul reiterates this idea: "Now you are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it" (1 Cor. 12:27). And if the point hadn't been made clearly enough, Paul writes the following words to the church at Ephesus: "And God placed all things under his feet and appointed him to be head over everything for the church, which is his body, the fullness of him who fills everything in every way" (Eph. 1:22–23; see also 5:23; Col. 1:18; 2:19).

Beyond the interconnectedness these passages suggest, they convey that the church is the locus of Christ's activity, and he works through the church now as he worked through his

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physical body during his thirty-three-year life. In the New Testament, there is simply no ministry outside the church, or at least its umbrella.

But what is this "local" church that functions as the body of Christ?

The earliest church, in the first forty or so years following the resurrection of Jesus, was essentially a movement within Judaism that believed the Messiah had come. But then, around AD 70, Jerusalem fell to the Romans, and the Christian church was dispersed. The most important church that emerged, as you would imagine, was the one in Rome, which was the capital of the Roman Empire.

During the next few centuries, the church defined itself by four very important words: *one*, *holy*, *catholic*, and *apostolic*. Each word carries great significance.[4] First, the church was to be one, or unified. Jesus, in his great and grand final prayer recorded in John's Gospel, prayed fervently for unity among those of us who would embrace his name in years and centuries to come. Second, it was to be a holy church, meaning set apart for God and separate from the world, for God himself is holy. The church was to reflect this holiness to the degree that it could be identified with God as holy. Third, the church was to be catholic, which simply means "universal." The church was meant to be a worldwide church, one that included all believers under its umbrella. So the word *catholic* was being used of the church long before any kind of institution within Christianity used it for its own. Finally, the church was to be apostolic, which means committed to the teaching handed down by Jesus through the apostles.

Beyond being one, holy, catholic, and apostolic, local churches were entities that had definition and form, structure and purpose. They were not simply doing "community" in the broadest of senses, much less simply pursuing ministry. In the Bible, the church was a defined, purposeful gathering of believers who knew they were coming together to *be* a church. There were defined entry and exit points to the church; clear theological guidelines navigating corporate and community waters; the responsibility of stewarding the sacraments; specifically named leadership positions; and, of course, a singular mission.

A very singular mission.

The church's mission, given by Jesus himself, is to reach out to a deeply fallen world and call it back to God. According to the Bible, this involves active evangelism with subsequent discipleship, coupled with strategic service to those in need, such as the poor. We are to be the body of Christ to this world, and the twin dynamics of evangelism and social concern reflect Christ's ongoing mission. And it is this cause that may be the most defining mark of all. Theologian Jürgen Moltmann reminds us that the church does not "have" a mission; rather, the mission "has" us.[5] And it is the mission of Christ that creates the church. God sent himself and now sends us. This is the *missio Dei*, the "sending of God." Or as Christopher J. H. Wright contends, our mission "means our committed participation as God's people, at God's invitation and command, in God's own mission within the history of God's world for the redemption of God's creation."[6] So to engage the mission of God is to engage his church; they are inextricably intertwined.

Which is why no conversation about reaching anyone, much less Generation Z, can proceed apart from the church. And there is no need to be awkward about being the church. The massive Pew study on the American religious landscape found that "most Americans continue to view organized religion as a force for good in American society." As the table below

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indicates, nearly nine out of ten adults said that “churches and other religious institutions bring people together and strengthen community bonds and that they play an important role in helping the poor and needy.” A surprising three-quarters added that “churches and other religious institutions help protect and strengthen morality in society.” These numbers were surprisingly robust and positive even among the religiously unaffiliated. So approaching Generation Z as the church and in the name of the church is not in and of itself a barrier. Indeed, it is their only hope, for it will take the body of Christ in its fullness to reach them.

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Religious Institutions Widely Viewed as Forces for Societal Good

Percent who agree that churches and other religious institutions . . .

	Bring people together and strengthen community bonds	Play important role in helping poor and needy	Protect and strengthen morality in society
Total	89	87	75
Christian Faiths	92	90	83
Protestant	93	91	85
Evangelical	94	92	87
Mainline	93	91	82
Historically black	89	88	81
Catholic	91	89	82
Orthodox Christian	93	87	74
Mormon	97	94	92
Jehovah's Witness	57	68	41
Non-Christian Faiths	86	82	62
Jewish	88	85	63
Muslim	88	89	83
Buddhist	86	78	65
Hindu	88	81	73
Unaffiliated	81	78	54
Atheist	75	71	31
Agnostic	85	84	52
Nothing in particular*	81	78	59
Religion not important	78	76	50
Religion important	86	81	71

*Those who describe their religion as "nothing in particular" are subdivided into two groups. The "religion not important" group includes those who say (in Q F2) religion is "not too" or "not at all" important in their lives as well as those who decline to answer the question about religion's importance. The "religion important" category includes those who say religion is "very" or "somewhat" important in their lives.

Source: 2014 Religious Landscape Study, conducted June 4–September 30, 2014, Pew Research Center. These questions were not asked in the 2007 Landscape Study.

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Nonetheless, there are barriers to overcome. Specifically, the accompanying perception that churches are "too concerned with money and power, too involved in politics and too focused on rules."[7] But the most pressing barriers to overcome are more foundational—namely, the barriers that come from being compromised, cloistered, or combative. As for being compromised, the church will have to understand that the key is being "counter" to a post-Christian culture, not a copy of it, or else we will have nothing to offer the world that it does not already have. In terms of being cloistered, we must avoid abdicating from cultural engagement by going into isolation. When it comes to being combative, we must avoid engaging culture in some kind of holy war. To be truly countercultural, in a manner impactful on a post-Christian generation, the church will need to take an approach that is entirely different from the three just described.

I will explore compromise in the next chapter, but for now, let's ensure we know what it means to be culturally engaged instead of cloistered or combative. These are such ongoing temptations that the church's recent history with such cultural ploys is worth recalling.

Remembering Fundamentalism

Fundamentalism was a retreat from everything perceived to threaten the bastions of what was understood to be true and orthodox.[8] Three major concerns occupied the fundamentalists in the years surrounding World War II. First was the influx of millions of immigrants and their various worldviews. Many of these were professing Roman Catholics, Lutherans, and Jews, none of whom shared the Puritan and revivalistic traditions of America and American evangelicalism. The second concern that occupied fundamentalists was the radical shift in contemporary thought, most famously evidenced by the Scopes Trial. The Scopes Trial typified such conflicts as the city versus the country, progress versus supposed ignorance, and most certainly modernism versus fundamentalism.

The trial itself revolved around a teacher who was charged and found guilty of violating the Tennessee antievolution law. Though fundamentalists "won" on the issue of evolution, some contend that the movement as a whole earned nothing but ridicule. This interpretation is based largely on the cross-examination of William Jennings Bryan by Scopes's attorney, Clarence Darrow, one of the most gifted attorneys in the nation. Bryan was unable to defend the Bible on the most simplistic points. As George Marsden has written, the trial brought an "outpouring of derision. The rural setting . . . stamped the entire movement with an indelible image," that of the anti-intellectual, Southern farmer.[9]

The third concern that occupied the fundamentalists was an approach to the Bible called higher criticism, an approach that was largely literary in nature and often began with a posture of skepticism: "Who really wrote this book of the Bible? Did that really happen the way the Bible says it did?" For fundamentalists, this criticism undermined the idea that the Bible was special revelation. Higher criticism was also associated with German liberalism in education and with Germany at the heart of both world wars during this era. It's no surprise that evangelist Billy Sunday quipped that if you turned hell upside down, you would find "Made in Germany" stamped on the bottom.[10]

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In such a context, fundamentalists decided to enter into a holy war and began to equate their success with the future of Western civilization.[11] This strong and emotive response to these three concerns, along with countless others, formed what Thomas Kuhn calls a paradigm shift.[12] Kuhn argues that science progresses not through the accumulation of new "facts" but through "paradigm conflicts" that exist between divergent worldviews. When two perspectives use radically different models and presuppositions, communication breakdown and conflict are inevitable. Marsden notes that Kuhn's theory helped explain and clarify the fundamentalist experience during this time of American history.[13]

After the 1920s, fundamentalism entered into a period perhaps best termed a "retreat into institutionalization." Rather than engage culture, fundamentalists retreated and sought areas where they could control doctrine, education, and morals. This isolation, of course, did little to alter the currents of culture. But neither did the Religious Right to which it eventually gave birth.

Remembering the Religious Right

Many fundamentalists grew uneasy with the denominational separatism, social and cultural irresponsibility, and anti-intellectual stance that pervaded during the years of controversy with the modernists.[14] These individuals branched off and formed the movement now known as contemporary American evangelicalism, led by such men as Carl F. H. Henry, Harold Ockenga, and Billy Graham and giving birth to such entities as the National Association of Evangelicals, Fuller Theological Seminary, and *Christianity Today* magazine. This new coalition gained national attention in 1976 when Jimmy Carter, a Southern Baptist and professed born-again evangelical, was elected president of the United States. *Newsweek* magazine declared 1976 "The Year of the Evangelical."[15] This newfound prominence led to the desire among certain evangelicals to shape contemporary culture and values. This was largely attempted through the political realm. The late 1970s saw the formation of organizations, such as the Moral Majority, that would come to typify the emergence of a Christian Right, or conservative Christian political activity that became associated with contemporary American evangelicalism. Such groups organized evangelicals to support the 1980 election of Ronald Reagan to the presidency of the United States and to lend their voices to a host of issues, including school prayer, tuition tax credits, and the reversal of Supreme Court decisions such as *Roe v. Wade*, which legalized abortion.

Two concerns fueled this politicization. First was an obsession, bordering on paranoia, with what was called secular humanism. Popularized as a tremendous threat to the continuing existence of Christianity, secular humanism was generally defined as the idea that humanity does not answer to any higher authority than humanity itself. Inherent within this definition was the correlate that human beings are basically good or can become good by their own efforts. As a result, many evangelicals understood secular humanism as a means to decide what was good and then to motivate humanity toward that goal without reference to God.[16] The second concern that brought many evangelicals into the public arena was the vision of a Christian America, the idea that America was founded as a Christian nation and flourished under the benevolent hand

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of Divine Providence and that America's blessings would remain only as long as America was faithful to God as a nation.[17]

Of course, this movement of contemporary American evangelicalism to become more involved in the political realm was not terribly successful, at least in terms of the immediate goals. Yes, Reagan was elected—twice—with the subsequent Supreme Court appointments. But the wider culture remained unaffected. Not only is *Roe v. Wade* still on the books, but we've also added *Obergefell v. Hodges*, which legalized gay marriage. As David Brooks assesses our day, the simple reality is that "American culture is shifting away from orthodox Christian positions on homosexuality, premarital sex, contraception, out-of-wedlock childbearing, divorce and a range of other social issues."[18]

So if the fundamentalist approach did not work (becoming cloistered), and neither did that of the Religious Right (becoming combative), what will? Before we can engage that question, we must have a clear sense of what we mean by the word *culture* itself.

The Meaning of Culture

So what is culture?

As a professor of mine once opined during my graduate school years, culture is the world in which we are born and the world that is born in us. Or, put another way, the world in which we live and the world that lives in us, which means we are talking about *everything*. Culture is the comprehensive, penetrating context that encompasses life and thought, art and speech, entertainment and sensibility, values and faith. It cannot be reduced to that which is simply economic or political, demographic or technological. Going further, the essence of culture, in regard to its most profound challenge, is that it is a spirit, a perspective on the world. It doesn't simply give a context for our values; it *shapes* our values because it has values in and of itself. It doesn't just provide the atmosphere for something such as communication; it forms what communication *is* and how it is achieved. Culture alters not only what is said but also what is heard—and how.

Sociologist Clifford Geertz has written some of the most penetrating and insightful definitions related to culture, and he has concluded that culture is "thick," meaning it cannot be reduced to any one thing. Instead, it is an entire way of life. And, he adds, it is largely self-created. Culture is something we invent, create, and fashion. Geertz, borrowing from fellow sociologist Max Weber, notes that "man is an animal suspended in webs of significance he himself has spun." Geertz then adds, "I take culture to be those webs."[19]

I was struck by a quote I came across one day: "'I am the art in your art houses, the ideas in your institutions, the laws in your land, the message in your movies, the thoughts of your teachers, the values your kids value. I affect you. Do you affect me?'—Culture."[20]

The Meaning of Countercultural

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As part of a project funded by the Hewlett Foundation, Michael Gerson and Peter Wehner interviewed a wide range of evangelical authors, academics, college presidents, and nonprofit leaders about the post-Christian cultural shift. "Without exception, the leaders we consulted believe evangelicals are at a pivot point in their relationship to American culture."[21] Those who once had power and influence, and have seen it slip away, feel fear and frustration. Usually, this is the older guard, many of whom were (or are) part of the Religious Right. Younger evangelicals have often met the change by retreating into an "apolitical Christian subculture." The idea is that simply living a life following Jesus will effect cultural change. Some have coined this the Benedict Option, named after Benedict of Nursia, who "inspired and organized a monastic alternative to the sins of ancient Rome." As Rod Dreher adds, the only answer is for Christians to "build resilient communities within our condition of internal exile."[22]

Gerson and Wehner are right when they take both approaches somewhat to task. "Instead of raging at the loss of influence or making grudging concessions to modernity," they write, "we might take this moment to display the essential character of Christianity—one that appeals and persuades outside the faith."[23] They take note of the work of Rodney Stark, a sociologist of religion, who has repeatedly detailed how the Jesus movement in the second and third centuries became the dominant faith of Western civilization (indeed, the world's largest religion). Stark points to the "communal compassion" and social networks of the early Christians as well as "their care for the sick, widows, and orphans; their welcoming of strangers and care for outsiders; their respect for women (who were considered second-class citizens); and their connection to non-Christians."[24]

I believe the so-called Benedict Option is not as far from this as Gerson and Wehner might think, however. As Dreher himself has written, "Given this post-Christian new 'dark age,' we . . . Christians must pioneer new ways to bind ourselves to Scripture, to our traditions, and to each other—not for mere survival, but so that the church can be the authentic light of Christ to a world lost in darkness."[25] If I might be so bold as to translate, our hope is for the church to be the church.

To be truly countercultural begins with being truly Christlike. We cannot convey anything related to the truth of Christ apart from reflecting Christ himself. As Gandhi once said, "I like your Christ, I do not like your Christians. Your Christians are so unlike your Christ."[26] We often marvel at the growth of the early church, the explosion of faith in Christ in such numbers and speed that in only a blink of history, the Roman Empire officially turned from paganism to Christianity. We look for formulas and programs, services and processes. The simple truth is that the early Christians were very much like Jesus, so much so that the name Christian, meaning "little Christ," came into existence (Acts 11). Yes, as Michael Green has noted, they shared the gospel like it was gossip over the backyard fence.[27] But what did people find when they responded to the evangelical call? As Tertullian noted, the awed pagan reaction to the Christian communal life was, "How these Christians seem to love each other."[28]

God Looks Good on You

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I recently read a line that caught my attention. One person said of another, “God looks good on you.” The context made it clear that the line didn’t mean God looked on them in a favorable way, as in God’s attitude or spirit toward them, but that when people looked at their life, it made God look good. God should look good on us to others. God looked good on Jesus. I’ve always marveled at how Jesus could proclaim absolute truth without compromise to those far from God and then those very people would invite him to their parties. Yet, as I wrote in *The Rise of the Nones*, we’re not quite pulling off the Jesus life.

Many of those outside the Christian faith think Christians no longer represent what Jesus had in mind—that Christianity in our society is not what it was meant to be. We’re seen as hyperpolitical, out of touch, pushy in our beliefs, and arrogant. And the biggest perceptions of all are that we are homophobic, hypocritical, and judgmental. Simply put, in the minds of many people, modern-day Christianity no longer seems Christian.

For example, in a video that’s been viewed over a million times on YouTube, songwriter and comedian Tim Minchin asks a Sydney, Australia, audience, “Are you up for a . . . sing?” Minchin begins to sing, “I love Jesus, I love Jesus.” He prompts the audience to join him. “Who do you love? Sing it!” Soon the whole crowd is involved, singing, “I love Jesus, I love Jesus.” Then Minchin changes the lyrics: “I love Jesus, I hate faggots, I love Jesus, I hate faggots.”

The crowd stops singing along.

Minchin looks up from his guitar as if he doesn’t understand the nature of the problem. “What happened? I just lost you there,” he says. After a halfhearted attempt to get the group singing again, he gives up. “Ah, well,” he says, “maybe these are ideas best shared in churches.”[29]

Much of that image has been earned. We’ve acted in ways, talked in ways, lived in ways that have stolen from God’s reputation. All this and more has flowed from the research of Gabe Lyons and David Kinnaman on how people view the church and people in it. Here’s the heart of what they found. Among young American “outsiders,” the following words or phrases were offered as possible descriptors of Christianity. The number who affirmed their accuracy is also included.[30]

- antihomosexual (91%)
- judgmental (87%)
- hypocritical (85%)
- old-fashioned (78%)
- too involved in politics (75%)
- out of touch with reality (72%)
- insensitive to others (70%)
- boring (68%)
- not accepting of other faiths (64%)
- confusing (61%)

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I commissioned a similar study in which researchers went to those who were unchurched and asked them a simple question: "How did the church and those inside it lose you?" I first published the results of the research, done in coordination with the Barna Research Group, in my book *Rethinking the Church*.[31] Comparing the two studies is interesting.

In my own earlier research, the unchurched gave the following reasons for abandoning the church:

- There is no value in attending (74%).
- Churches have too many problems (61%).
- I do not have the time (48%).
- I am simply not interested (42%).
- Churches ask for money too frequently (40%).
- Church services are usually boring (36%).
- Christian churches hold no relevance for the way I live (34%).
- I do not believe in God or I am unsure that God exists (12%).

Such findings pointed to a culture that was saying, "God, yes; church, no." Now research shows the deepening crisis, for it points to a culture that says, "God, perhaps; Christianity and Christians, no." The idea of even considering church is seemingly off the table. But not because those outside the church don't see value in the church. And not because the church itself, as the body of Christ, is not the hope of the world. The problem is the church is not being the church, much less a countercultural one. If we were, then God would begin to look good on us again—even if what we say is alien to every other voice the unchurched might be hearing.

People will often look at Mecklenburg Community Church and wonder what the attraction is to the unchurched. Spend a week with us and you'll see. There is unity and love among the attenders. Grace flows freely with truth as its banner. In the midst of family dysfunction, there is authentic community. You'll be challenged to join us in rescuing sex-trafficked young girls from the brothels in the Philippines, work with orphans in Argentina, and serve the working poor on our doorstep. You will be challenged to consider having Christ intersect the deepest needs of your life and then grow deep in that relationship. You will be confronted with the reality of having one and only one life and then making that life count.

It's infectious.

How the Irish Saved Civilization

But being countercultural by fleshing out the life of Christ is not enough if the understanding of that life of Christ is devoid of the attempt to actively influence the post-Christian culture. Being countercultural is more about how best to exert that influence. In 1995, Thomas Cahill came out with the provocatively titled book *How the Irish Saved Civilization*. "Ireland," contends Cahill,

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> had one moment of unblemished glory. . . . As the Roman Empire fell, as all through Europe matted, unwashed barbarians descended on the Roman cities, looting artifacts and burning books, the Irish, who were just learning to read and write, took up the great labor of copying all of Western literature.[32]

Then missionary-minded Irish monks brought what had been preserved on their isolated island back to the continent, refounding European civilization. And that, Cahill concludes, is how the Irish saved civilization.

But there is more at hand in Cahill's study than meets the eye. Cahill notes that, beyond the loss of Latin literature and the development of the great national European literatures that an illiterate Europe would not have established, something else would have perished in the West: "The habits of the mind that encourage thought." Why would this matter? Cahill continues his assessment: "And when Islam began its medieval expansion, it would have encountered scant resistance to its plans—just scattered tribes of animists, ready for a new identity." Without a robust mind to engage the onslaught—and a Christian one at that—the West would have been under the crescent instead of the cross.[33]

Never before have the habits of the mind mattered more. As Winston Churchill presciently stated in his address to Harvard University in 1943, "The empires of the future will be empires of the mind." Oxford theologian Alister McGrath, reflecting on Churchill's address, noted that Churchill's point was that a great transition was taking place in Western culture with immense implications for all who lived in it. The powers of the new world would not be nation-states, as with empires past, but ideologies. Ideas, not nations, would captivate and conquer in the future. The starting point for the conquest of the world would now be the human mind.[34] Or as John Stott once proclaimed, "We may talk of 'conquering' the world for Christ. But what sort of 'conquest' do we mean? Not a victory by force of arms. . . . This is a battle of ideas."[35]

Yet as I wrote in *A Mind for God*, there are surprisingly few warriors. Those who follow Christ have too often retreated into personal piety and good works. Or as one BBC commentator I heard on the radio while jogging one morning in Oxford said, Christians have too often offered mere "feelings" and "philanthropy." Speaking specifically to the challenge from Islam, he added that what is needed is more "hard thinking" applied to the issues of the day.

Which is why finding our cultural voice is more pressing than ever.

Discussion Questions

1. At the beginning of this chapter, you read the following quote from John Stott referring to the teachings of Jesus: "If the church realistically accepted his standards and values . . . and lived by them, it would be the alternative society he always intended it to be, and would offer to the world an authentic Christian counter-culture." Does that spark anything in you that has been missing for some time?
2. In your life and ministry, how do you feel the vision of the church is perceived by those around you? How does that view differ from Jesus's own vision for the church?

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3. The church's mission, according to the Bible, involves active evangelism with subsequent discipleship, coupled with strategic service to those in need. Which part of that mission is your ministry lacking? Which part are you actively working on?
4. Do you think the church acting as the church is a barrier or a blessing to Generation Z? Why do you feel this way?
5. The church is supposed to be a counterculture that is different from anything around it. That involves not being isolated from society and not conforming to society. Do you or your church tend toward one of the two? What can you do this year to move toward becoming a true counterculture in the way the Bible explains it?
6. Culture is the world in which we live and the world that lives in us. It doesn't simply give a context for our values; it *shapes* our values because it has values in and of itself. Does this mesh with your previous understanding of culture? If not, what does this definition cause you to think about that you may have been missing?
7. We cannot convey anything related to the truth of Christ apart from reflecting Christ himself. Be honest with yourself. Are there areas of your life or your ministry that are not reflecting Christ? What can you do to change that starting today?

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